FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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From Policy to Practice: How Groundwater Agencies Are Turning Plans into Action

TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN SGMA UPDATE

by Julie Martella

Groundwater agencies across the Tulare Lake Subbasin are gaining momentum. As lawsuits delay direct state enforcement, local leaders are pushing ahead, finalizing allocations, approving fee structures, and laying the groundwork for real-time accountability.

Where Things Stand: GSA Progress This Month

Mid-Kings River GSA

In August, the Mid-Kings River GSA continued the shift from planning to action. The Board formally approved the Domestic Well Mitigation Program, designed to help residents whose wells go dry due to changing groundwater levels. The program includes:

- Emergency bottled water and temporary tank systems
- Long-term solutions, such as mitigation, new wells, or service connections
- A $2 million reserve fund supported by pumping fees
- Coverage for wells impacted after January 1, 2015

The Board also approved contracts with Geosyntec for a sustainable yield study covering the entire Tulare Lake Subbasin, and with Land IQ for evapotranspiration tracking services.

To fund future operations, including monitoring, mitigation, and enforcement, the Board discussed potential fee structures. Staff was directed to move quickly to develop a GSA-wide funding plan. While one board member mentioned a Prop 218 election, it has not yet been officially proposed. Further discussion is expected in September.

The Stakeholder Advisory Committee remained active as a technical workgroup, meeting biweekly to continue working on two major management plans:

1. **Subsidence Management Plan:** This plan uses 2020 as a baseline to monitor subsidence. It establishes acceptable limits and develops a tiered response system when declining water level triggers are reached.
2. **Groundwater Allocation Plan:** This plan specifies annual groundwater pumping limits, starting with higher allowances and gradually decreasing through 2040.

South Fork Kings GSA

South Fork's Grower Advisory Committee continued to move key policies forward this month. Most notably, the group is proposing five-year step-downs for groundwater allocations, giving stakeholders a more predictable planning

"GSA Roundup" continued on page 14

Activists Gather at Vera Goat Dairy on July 15

By Steve Pastis

Activists from across the state returned to Kings County on July 15 to protest what they claimed is the cruel treatment of goats at Vera Goat Dairy and the failure of county authorities to take action.

An organization called Direct Action Everywhere (DXE) held protests at three county locations to follow up on its similar action in May.

"We had a protest at the district attorney's and sheriff's office urging them specifically to address the documented conditions at Vera Goat Dairy, to go out there and investigate, and prosecute as needed," said Cassie King, DXE organizer. "And then we also had a vigil at Vera Goat Dairy to bear witness, so it was a two-part action."

The action included "a lot of signs" and "a LED light display attached to one activist truck that was playing footage from Vera Goat Dairy," she said. "We had that at both locations, the protests in the earlier afternoon and then the vigil after

Protestors carrying goats away from Vera Goat Dairy during the first protest in May. (Photo courtesy of Direct Action Everywhere)

"Dairy Protest" continued on page 11

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Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
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Reliable | Trusted Resource

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

Dusty Ference

The Kings County Farm Bureau's lawsuit against the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) has reached another critical stage. Early last month, the Fifth District Court of Appeal issued a notice to both parties asking if they wished to waive oral arguments in the appeal. This procedural step may sound technical, but it provides us with a clear sense of where the case is headed and what comes next for our farmers and landowners.

When a case is appealed, the court often holds oral arguments. This is the point in the process where attorneys for both sides appear before a panel of appellate judges to answer questions and reinforce the written legal briefs that have already been submitted. Oral arguments are not trials. No new evidence is introduced, no witnesses are called, and no jury is present. Instead, the judges take the opportunity to probe the legal positions each side has staked out in their filings. Some appeals are decided without oral arguments if the judges believe the written record is clear enough. That is why the court asked if either party wanted to waive the chance to appear in person.

In this case, the SWRCB has already indicated that it wants oral arguments. That means the case will not be decided on the briefs alone. Oral arguments will be scheduled, and the judges will prepare to hear directly from attorneys on both sides. For us, this is not a setback. Oral argument gives KCFB's legal team the chance to respond directly to the Board's positions, to highlight the flaws in the state's case, and to emphasize the very real consequences that the probation decision has for our farming community.

We now know that oral arguments will be scheduled in October, though the exact date has not yet been announced. Once that date is set, the judges and their clerks will intensify their review of the written briefs. Oral argument is their opportunity to clarify points of law and fact before making a decision. After the hearing, the judges will deliberate privately and then issue a written opinion. That opinion will either affirm the state's authority, reverse the decision, or send the matter back to the lower court with instructions.

For our members, what matters most is that this stage shows progress. Appeals take time, and every procedural step can feel slow. But each move brings us closer to a resolution. The court's request for oral arguments means the case is fully briefed, the record is complete, and the judges are preparing to evaluate the arguments head-on. It also means our legal team will have the chance to make the strongest possible case for why the SWRCB's overreach cannot stand.

It is important to keep in mind why we are here. When the Board voted to place the Tulare Lake Subbasin on probation, it set in motion a regulatory and financial burden on our local farmers and landowners that was both unfair and unnecessary. KCFB took the lead in challenging that action because no one else was going to stand up for the men and women who feed and fuel this region. Through this lawsuit, we are not just arguing about paperwork or process. We are protecting your right to farm, your ability to manage groundwater locally, and your bottom line. Every month that this case moves forward, we are preventing costly new fees and preserving local control of our water future.

The months ahead will be critical. Oral arguments in October will allow the judges to hear our position in full and understand the consequences of upholding the SWRCB's decision. The outcome of this appeal will set a precedent not only for Kings County but also for farming communities across California, which are watching as Sacramento seeks to expand its control. Our fight is bigger than one basin; it is about whether farmers themselves will have a voice in how groundwater is managed.

As your Executive Director, I want to assure you that KCFB remains fully committed to this fight. We are putting every resource we have into ensuring your voice is heard in the courtroom. But this is not something we can do alone. We need the continued backing of our membership to sustain this effort. Later in this issue of Farm Life, you will see a "Join the Fight" advertisement with details on how to contribute to the SGMA Defense Fund. I encourage every member to read it carefully and consider how you can help.

The path through the courts is never short or simple, but we are moving forward. The Fifth District Court of Appeal has set oral arguments for October, and that means our day in court is almost here. With your continued support, we will be ready.

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

Water quality panel focuses on agricultural nitrogen use

As California water officials consider new rules, farmer advocates are pushing back against strict limits on how much nitrogen farmers can apply to their crops. Kari Fisher, senior counsel and director of legal advocacy for the California Farm Bureau, said it is too soon to adopt nitrogen limits, as the industry is still gathering and evaluating data to develop realistic targets. "We have found that the one-size-fits-all nitrogen and application reporting requirements don't necessarily fit with how agriculture is grown in the state because of differences related to commodity type, where crops are grown and reliance on surface water versus groundwater and the like," Fisher said.

California Farm Bureau Submits Comments on USDA's Reorganization Proposal

Last month, California Farm Bureau submitted comments to the U.S. Department of Agriculture regarding its proposed reorganization plan. Announced last month, the plan would shift some USDA operations from Washington, D.C., to five "regional hubs," including Fort Collins, Colorado, and Salt Lake City, Utah. The proposal, however, lacked detail on the selection process and the specific functions of these hubs. Farm Bureau raised concerns about California being overlooked as a hub location, the potential loss of staff and institutional knowledge, and the risk of shuttering existing USDA sub-agency offices in the state. Next steps remain uncertain, as this is not a typical rulemaking process with a clear review structure. The public comment period has been extended to Aug. 31.

Almond markets jolted by large crop forecast

After farming at a loss for as many as five consecutive years, California almond growers watched prices climb for much of the past year, promising a return to profitability. Then, right before harvest, the U.S. Department of Agriculture released an unexpectedly high crop forecast of 3 billion pounds. "That shocked the market," said Ali Amin, owner of Primex International Trading, a major nut exporter based in Los Angeles. Anticipating a glut, buyers pulled back, causing almond prices to drop nearly 20% overnight. The reaction erased roughly a billion dollars from the total crop value, and it eliminated the profit margin for many farmers. "You wake up at 5 in the morning and work until 10 at night, and you can't break even," said Jasbir Sidhu, who began harvesting almonds in Fresno and Madera counties the first week of August

U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service Pauses Blanket 4(d) Rule

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service will rescind its "blanket 4(d) rule," which extended full Endangered Species Act protections to threatened species. Critics cited impacts on species such as the gray wolf. The rule was removed in 2019, reinstated in 2024 and now set for replacement by October 2026 after review.

EPA Rules California Cannot Regulate Out-of-State Trucks

Late last week, the federal government announced a pause on issuing worker visas for commercial truck drivers. The decision follows national attention on traffic fatalities allegedly involving commercial truck drivers and concerns about the English proficiency of commercial driver's license holders. The U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) has proposed that California's program to regulate out-of-state heavy-duty vehicles is impermissible. Clean Truck Check requirements for vehicles registered in California will still apply. EPA argues California's Heavy-Duty Inspection and Maintenance (I/M) program violates the commerce clause of the Constitution. The rule is open for public comment until Sept. 25.

High beef prices keep U.S. cattle numbers low

The supply of cattle in the U.S. is historically low, and market dynamics for ranchers could sustain the trend for some time. With their animals earning record-high prices, ranchers are more inclined to sell calves for cash rather than keep them for breeding, growing the nation's herd. After drought annihilated their herds, many cow-calf operators are "finally getting out of the red a little bit," Calaveras County rancher Michael David Fischer said, and with current cattle prices "going absolutely crazy, it encourages them to sell." Abbi Prins, an industry analyst for CoBank in Minnesota, said she expects the size of the nation's beef cowherd won't start to see signs of expansion until 2027 because it takes nearly two years for heifer calves born this year to produce their own calves.

New Details on U.S.-EU Details Emerge

The White House unveiled new details on a trade deal with the European Union, which follows up on a tentative agreement announced earlier this summer. EU countries will have a (current) 27.5% tariff on U.S. auto exports lowered to 15% when it introduces legislation to give preferential access to a variety U.S. agricultural goods and eliminate tariffs on U.S. industrial products. The agricultural products include tree nuts, dairy products, fruits and vegetables, processed foods, planting seeds, soybean oil, pork and bison meat. The EU will also address concerns of U.S. producers about the EU Deforestation Regulation to avoid impacts on U.S.-EU trade.

Use of Animal Drugs to Combat NWS

Earlier this week, the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services announced it would issue Emergency Use Authorizations to the U.S. Food and Drug Administration as it looks to combat the potential spread of New World Screwworm (NWS). NWS popped up in Mexico earlier this year, and the U.S. Department of Agriculture has been ramping up mitigation efforts domestically and south of the border. Emergency Use Authorizations would allow FDA emergency usage and approval of animal drugs for the treatment and/or prevention of infestations caused by NWS. It remains to be seen which exact drugs this could include, as there has historically been no FDA-approved drug associated with NWS.

USDA OBBA Crop Insurance Implementation

In August, the U.S. Department of Agriculture Risk Management Agency announced it would move quickly to implement crop insurance changes approved under the One Big Beautiful Bill Act—the reconciliation package passed by Congress earlier this year. Some of the changes address beginning farmer or rancher benefits, area-based crop insurance coverage, Whole-Farm Revenue Protection improvements and updated premium subsidiary rates. Agencies have typically struggled to move quickly to implement funds approved in larger legislative bills, so this should be an encouraging sign that the administration is eager to see key portions of the bill move to the implementation phase.

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First Fridays with Farm Bureau Kicks Off Strong

Kings County Farm Bureau hosted its first First Fridays with Farm Bureau lunch September 5, and the turnout showed just how important this new tradition could become. A broad audience of farmers, ranchers, rural landowners, and community members joined us at the KCFB office for food and conversation.

The discussion centered on two major issues: KCFB's lawsuit against the State Water Resources Control Board and current activities within the Tulare Lake Subbasin GSAs. Attendees engaged in a straightforward, productive exchange of ideas that reflected the strength of our agricultural community.

This was the first in what we hope will be a long-running tradition at KCFB, an open, community-forward space to share updates and discuss the issues that matter most to our members.

Our next First Fridays with Farm Bureau lunch is scheduled for Friday, October 3, 2025. We invite everyone to join us, grab a meal, and be part of the conversation.

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Measuring Fecal Pathogens in Almond Orchard Soils Post-Grazing

By Julie Finzel, Range and Livestock Farm Advisor

Julie Finzel

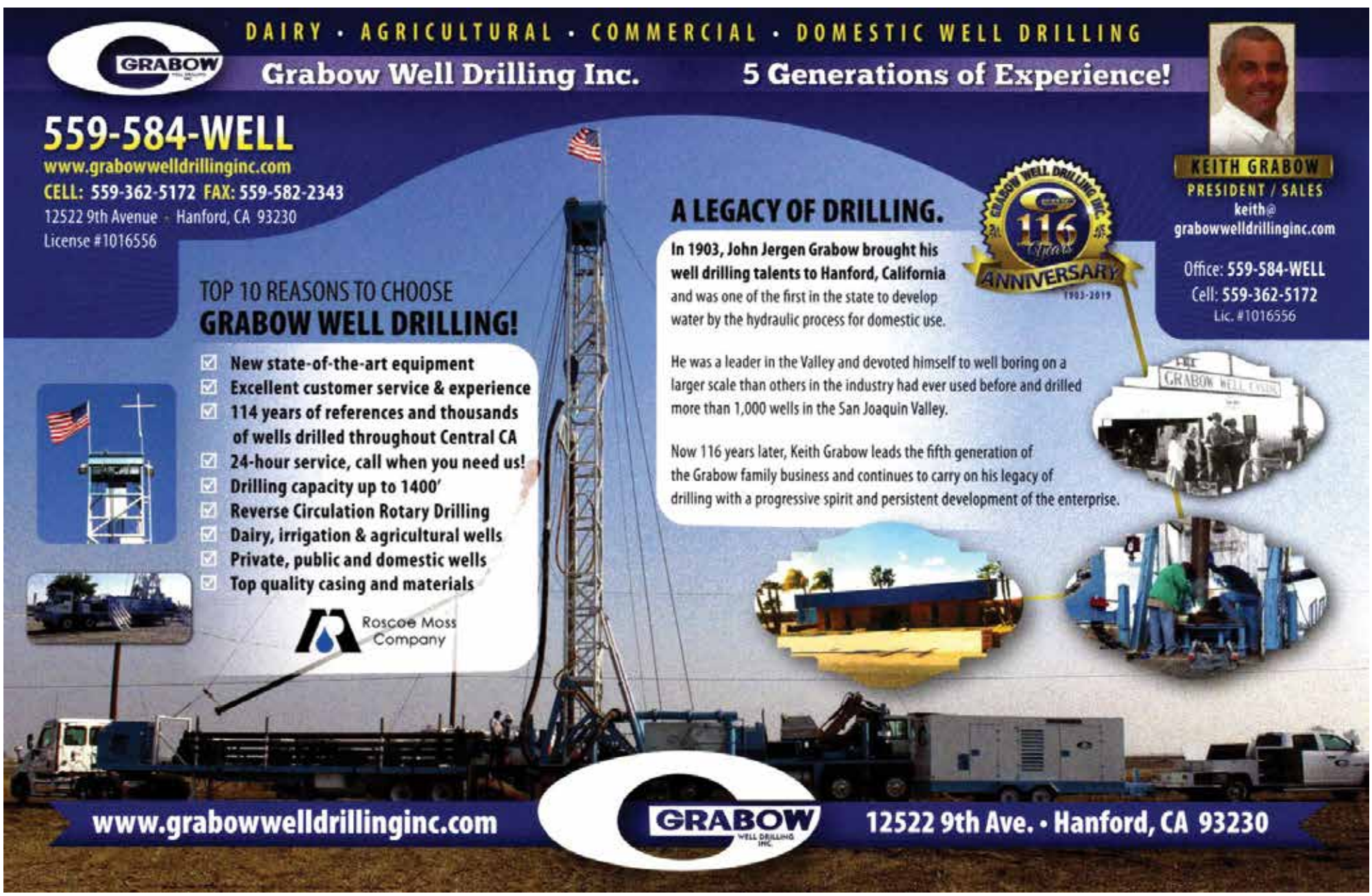
Interest in using sheep to help manage cover crops and improve soil health in orchards is growing. However, food safety concerns exist because almond harvest is done in part on the ground.

In response to this concern, my team and I designed a two-year research project to measure fecal pathogens in the soil of grazed almond orchards. We have two study sites; both are managed using cover crops and sheep grazing. We collected manure samples from the sheep, soil samples prior to grazing, and soil samples zero to 120 days post-grazing in regular, timed intervals on grazed and ungrazed blocks. Pathogen analysis focused on variants of E. coli, including E. coli O157:H7.

While this was a two-year study, we currently only have results from the first year to share. In Year 1, six out of 20 manure samples tested positive E. coli O157:H7 from Farm A and nine out of 20 manure samples tested positive for generic E. coli from Farm B. From a total of 300 soil samples collected, two soil samples tested positive, both post-grazing. On Farm A, one soil sample from Day Zero post-grazing tested positive for generic E. coli. On Farm B, one soil sample from Day 60 post-grazing tested positive for both generic E. coli and E. coli O157:H7. Both samples were from the wetting zone under the tree canopy. We were not able to test to determine if the positive samples were from sheep or from another source. But it should be noted that past Day 60, there were no positive samples for any fecal coliforms on either orchard. The current standard practice is to have animals removed a minimum of 120 days prior to harvest.

Another concern when integrating grazing into orchard management is potential costs. As part of this study we looked at potential costs and returns when integrating sheep grazing. In our analysis we included a grazing fee of $60/acre for 2 passes through an orchard (of note, sheep only made one pass in both orchards in this study). Cost savings included less mowing, one less herbicide application, reduced sweep and mow for naval orangeworm winter sanitation, and less compost application. No reduced revenue or additional revenue was included in the calculations. Altogether, our budget analysis showed a potential savings of $7 an acre.

The preliminary findings from this study are promising. No samples tested positive for fecal pathogens past 60 days post-grazing indicating that the current 120 day rule is sufficient to maintain the food safety of ground-harvested almonds post-grazing. Further, our budget analysis indicates that integrating sheep grazing can have a positive impact on the bottom line for almond producers. Sheep producers in the southern San Joaquin valley have mobile operations, well-suited to seasonal orchard grazing. However, sheep producers must place priority on the well-being of their sheep and maintaining a strong business model. As a result, the availability of sheep for orchard grazing may be limited in some circumstances. It is important to work closely with the livestock producer to balance the almond production schedule with the logistics of livestock production.



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Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

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A Serious Threat to Waterways

Alligator weed (Alternanthera philoxeroides) is a highly invasive aquatic plant that poses a serious threat to waterways such as canals, rivers, lakes and drainage systems. Native to South America, the fast growing weed spread too many parts of the world, including the United States, Australia, and Asia. Due to its aggressive growth and adaptability the weed can spread rapidly across various region. Particularly in warmer climates, alligator weed can cause significant environmental, economical, and infrastructural damage.

Alligator weed can affect waterways by forming dense mats on the surface of water bodies. In canals and drainage ditches, these mats can block the natural flow of water, causing flooding and reducing the efficiency of irrigation systems. This can affect agricultural productivity and increase maintenance cost for water management agencies. The thick growth of alligator weed reduces oxygen levels in the water by preventing sunlight from penetrating and disrupting photosynthesis of native aquatic plants. This leads to stagnant conditions, which can promote the growth of harmful algae and decrease biodiversity. The weed can obstruct boating, fishing, and other recreational activities by clogging waterways. In navigational canals, it can also interfere with the movement of vessels, causing economic losses in commercial transport or tourism sectors. When it outcompetes native aquatic plants for sunlight, nutrients, and space, alligator weed disrupts ecosystems and leads to a decline in native biodiversity. Its mats can also create breeding grounds for pests such as mosquitos, raising public health concerns.

Controlling alligator weed requires a combination of mechanical, chemical, and biological strategies. The choice of method depends on the scale of the infestation, type of waterway, and environmental sensitivity of the area. Small infestations can be managed with hand tools, by hand pulling or cutting, but it is very labor intensive. In large canals, equipment can be used to mechanically cut and remove surface mats of the aquatic weed. However, the method often leaves fragments behind, which can regrow, spreading the infestation. These methods can provide a temporary solution but is rarely a long-term solution. Aquatic approved herbicides, such as those containing glyphosate or 2,4-D, can be used to manage alligator weed. These chemicals are absorbed into the plants' system after spraying on the leaves. Chemical control is effective over large areas and relatively quick to apply but repeated applications are often necessary. Caution must be used near water bodies to avoid harming non-target species and contamination water supplies if chemical applications are made. Natural enemies from the weeds native range can help reduce populations. The Alligator Weed Flea Beetle feeds on the leaves of alligator weed and has been successfully used in several countries. The biological agents typically perform better in warm, humid conditions and may not fully eradicate the weed. An integrated management plan using herbicides to knock back large infestations, following up with mechanical removal of dead plant matter and introduction of biological agents to suppress is the most effective.

Alligator weed is a serious invasive species that can damage ecosystems, economies, and infrastructure, particularly in waterways like canals, rivers, lakes and drainage systems. While no single control method offers a perfect solution, a combination of mechanical, chemical, and biological techniques tailored to specific local conditions can effectively manage and reduce the impact of this aggressive plant. Ongoing vigilance and coordinated management efforts are key to protecting valuable water resources from this invasive weed. Please contact the Kings County Agricultural Commissioner's office at 559-852-2830 if you have any questions.

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Kings County Agriculture Exports: Feeding the World

Kings County agriculture continues to make its mark far beyond the San Joaquin Valley. According to the 2023 Kings County Crop Report, our farmers and ranchers exported commodities to dozens of countries, with three markets standing out as top destinations: Canada, China, and Japan.

Canada remains the leading customer for Kings County commodities. From dairy products to pistachios and cotton, Canadian buyers rely heavily on the consistent quality of California agriculture.

China follows closely, importing significant volumes of pistachios, cotton, and dairy. As one of the largest markets in the world, China's demand underscores how central Kings County production is to global supply chains.

Japan continues its reputation as a discerning consumer market, purchasing high-quality dairy and specialty nuts from local producers. Japanese buyers' focus on premium quality is a strong vote of confidence in what Kings County farmers deliver.

WHY IT MATTERS

Together, these three countries represent more than half of Kings County's agricultural export reach. They highlight the county's role not just as a regional supplier, but as a global powerhouse in agriculture.

AT A GLANCE

- Top Destinations: Canada, China, Japan
- Key Commodities: Dairy, pistachios, cotton
- Global Impact: Kings County exports stretch across continents, strengthening the local economy while feeding families around the world.

"Dairy Protest" continued from page 1

that."

King described DXE as an international network involved in a lot of different campaigns "advocating for animals," with the mission "to achieve revolutionary change for animals."

The Kings County Rural Crime Task Force ("the Ag Unit") was prepared for DXE on July 15.

"Probably a month prior, they had come out, and it was kind of semi-surprise," said Ag Unit Detective Carlos Santos. "This time, we knew they were coming out based off a social media post that we read. It was on their Facebook page that they were going to be coming out, so we were ready for them."

Kings County Farm Bureau Executive Director Dusty Ference was impressed by the way Kings County Ag Crimes Unit handled things. "I want to commend the Ag Crimes Unit for taking such a proactive approach to what could have been a real issue," he said. "I don't know too many agencies around that would have realized that this protest was going on, and would have proactively gone out and had officers onsite undercover, ready to act in the event that they needed to."

Santos said everything at the July protests went peacefully. "They did their protest," he said. "They were on the shoulder of the road in front of the business. They never came into the business, so that was all good. They did wind up here at the DA's office protesting outside, and then coming over to the sheriff's office, which is next door.

"I wound up coming out here, talking to them," he continued. "I pulled two people aside. I asked to speak to them alone. We went over their concerns. I spoke to them for an hour-and-a-half or so."

At the May protest, some DXE members carried goats away from Vera Goat Dairy. "This recent one that I dealt with, there was none of that at all," Santos said. "They were out there with their signs and doing their thing, but they never came into the facility."

DXE's Request for an Investigation

Kings County District Attorney Sarah Hacker acknowledged receiving DXE's request for an investigation of Vera Goat Dairy.

"I was aware that they had entered a complaint to the Rural Crimes Unit of the Sheriff's Department," she said. "At that time, they submitted their complaint to the Rural Crimes Unit and investigators followed through on their investigation. They didn't find any of the allegations true or founded.

"The Rural Crimes Unit did end up looking into how to dispose of goat carcasses or goat remains," Hacker said. "They cannot be buried. They can't be burned. You can contract with a landfill company, but that option is cost-prohibitive, so what a lot of goat farmers do is compost the remains."

The State Water Resources Control Board will not let goat farmers bury dead goats. "It's illegal to bury them, so the farmer composts the bodies," she said. "He doesn't bury them underground, but he takes the bodies and he puts manure over the top of them so that the bacteria from the manure assists in the composting process."

"There's environmental issues and so there's no great way to do that," Santos said. "I investigated this whole thing from beginning to end and there's not a solid way you dispose of goats."

He said that placing dead goats in a pile is "the best option at this point," adding that Vera Goat Dairy did nothing criminally wrong.

No Charges Filed

No charges were filed against the protesters for either the May or July actions, even though a few protesters at the May action were arrested on trespass charges.

The May incident was investigated, but it "did not end up yielding a case that we could prosecute," Hacker explained.

"The charges have not been filed formally, so they're in a waiting period of waiting to see if the charges get filed," King said. "That could happen any time because there's a long clock that runs. They might never be filed, or they might have these charges filed in a year, so it's just a kind of inactive case, I guess you could call it right now."

Protesters were not arrested for theft for carrying goats away from Vera Goat Dairy during the May protest.

"They were never arrested on anything but trespass, not to say that there couldn't be theft charges filed because they certainly published video with their faces in it of them rescuing the animals," King said. "They had nothing to hide and no intention to deny that they did rescue them. They came right back to the facility and they told the authorities what they had just done and seen, and that's why they were arrested."

The July 15 incident is over, according to Hacker. "The case is closed and we're not taking any further action," she said. "I think that we just had a very fair inquiry into both sides, and the evidence all pointed towards Vera Goat Dairy running an ethical and humane operation.

"Part of the issue with the DXE's evidence against the dairy is that they produced photographs and videos and lab results, but they did not authenticate any of those documents," she said. "They wouldn't explain how they got this information, and how they know that this information is related to Vera Goat Dairy. When they contacted Investigator Santos, they did not specify where they got their information from."

No other protests in Kings County are planned, at least not currently. "Direct Action Everywhere monitors factory farms across California," King said. "We have a large presence in California, and we do our best to surveil and keep an eye out on these facilities. That's actually how we discovered the dead pile at Vera, through drone surveillance of factory farms in the area and seeing the dead pile, and that's what prompted an investigation. I don't have knowledge at this point that there's another goat farm that's already caught the attention of animal cruelty investigators, but that very well could happen in the future."

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

Contributed by Detective Santos

In the month of August, the Rural Crimes Unit conducted a lengthy burglary investigation which occurred at an agriculture business located in the area of Highway 43 and Fargo Avenue in Hanford. During this burglary a gun safe was stolen with multiple rifles and pistols inside. While conducting our investigation we located a crucial piece of evidence the suspect had left behind at the scene which led us to identify the suspect. A search warrant was conducted at his residence in Hanford where the safe was located and approximately half of the guns were recovered. Just prior to the search the suspect was apprehended by Fresno's MAGEC Unit in Fresno. He was transported back to Kings County where he was booked into the Kings County Jail with a bail amount of $1.9 million dollars. The Rural Crimes Unit has also identified a second subject who we believe assisted with stealing the gun safe. A warrant has been issued for his arrest as well.

The Rural Crimes Unit continues to prioritize investigating copper wire thefts and have made several arrests this month. We have had a few pump wire thefts during this month which were mostly in the south end of the county near 25th Ave and Utica Ave in Kettleman City. While conducting follow-up in the Kettleman City area a vehicle, which we believed was associated with wire thefts, was located parked at a residence. Later that afternoon the same vehicle was located in Hanford and a traffic stop was conducted. There were two male subjects and one female subject in the vehicle during the stop. A vehicle search was conducted and approximately 70 pounds of stolen wire was located inside the vehicle. Two male subjects were arrested for wire theft and the female subject for being under the influence of a controlled substance. Their vehicle was also towed.

In the area of 17th Ave and Iona Ave a 1000-gallon, white, poly water tank, which was mounted on a tandem axle trailer was stolen. The trailer is green in color and approximately 15 feet in length, with a smaller Honda engine mounted on the trailer tongue.

In the area of 23 ½ Ave and Elder Ave in Riverdale a Kubota tractor was stolen last week. The tractor is described as an older Kubota 8030, 4x4, with a missing front grill.

If you locate any of the above-mentioned stolen equipment, please contact the Kings County Sheriffs Office Dispatch at (559) 852-2720. You may also contact me or any of our unit members with any questions or concerns.

Detective Santos (559) 904-6893
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window through 2040. This draft hasn't been submitted to the Board yet, but the intent is clear: to develop a farmer-friendly plan that still meets the sustainable yield deadline under SGMA.

On subsidence, the committee voted to align with neighboring GSAs by adopting a 2020 baseline year and updating the management zones. The revised map sharpens tracking and adds flexibility where possible.

Well registration hit a milestone, with more than 50% of South Fork parcels now registered. This marks a substantial improvement from earlier in the year and reflects growing engagement across the region.

In parallel, the Watermark platform is now fully operational. It's a new online dashboard that gives each grower access to their own groundwater account. Farmers can now view their parcels on a map, locate their wells, and input relevant data directly.

Finally, the Kings County Board of Supervisors approved a JPA amendment that will add two grower seats to the GSA Board. For this change to take effect, the remaining four JPA members—the City of Lemoore, Stratford Public Utility District, Empire West Side Irrigation District, and Stratford Irrigation District—must approve it at their upcoming board meetings.

Tri-County Water Authority

In the Tulare Lake area of the Tri-County Water Authority, important policy decisions were made this month. The agency finalized an updated groundwater allocation policy, a subsidence management policy, and a domestic well mitigation program. Legal counsel is reviewing a Coordination Agreement with neighboring GSAs, though questions remain about aligning minimum thresholds for subsidence across the subbasin. A separate Groundwater Sustainability Plan (GSP) is also being developed.

El Rico GSA

By Geoff Vanden Heuvel
Director of Regulatory and Economic Affairs, Milk Producers Council

I attended the El Rico GSA board meeting in Corcoran. This GSA is in the Tulare Lake Subbasin, which was placed on probation by the State Water Board in April of 2024. The State Board has not been enforcing probation due to a preliminary injunction issued by the Superior Court in Kings County in response to a lawsuit filed by the Kings County Farm Bureau against the State Board.

Several interesting topics were discussed at the El Rico meeting. The landowners there are required to register their wells, install meters, and report their pumping every quarter. There are a small number of farmers who are refusing to comply. The El Rico board discussed what steps the GSA should take to compel compliance. They did not act at this meeting, but it appears that there are costs that can be assessed for non-compliance, backed by legal action, which will certainly increase the pain for landowners who disregard the GSA rules.

Another topic that came up was a response letter El Rico prepared to an article published in SJV Water entitled, "Boswell silent and 'blank' as the farming behemoth continues with plans to sink the Tulare Lakebed another 10 feet." The response letter that was approved by the El Rico board pointed out some errors and mistakes that were in the article, which it asked the article's author to correct. It also highlighted some strong differences El Rico has over policy with some of their neighboring Tulare Lake GSA.

Southwest Kings GSA

The Southwest Kings GSA did not hold a board meeting this month. However, they did reach out to South Fork Kings GSA to discuss potential collaboration on recharge and enforcement efforts.

Translating Policy Into Real Life

Many of this month's policies are tied to meeting the requirements of the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act. Their approval and implementation represent an important step in maintaining SGMA decisions under local control rather than deferring to the State. These changes impact how water use will be monitored, reported, and managed moving forward.

- **Groundwater allocations** will set the amount of water each parcel can pump. Allocations will decrease over time, and pumping will need to be tracked and reported.
- **Overpumping penalties** will apply when allocations are exceeded. Enforcement will occur through tracking systems, billing, and, if necessary, legal action.
- **Domestic well mitigation** will support residents impacted by dry wells resulting from groundwater pumping activities. Services may include, but are not limited to, emergency bottled water, interim tank systems, and other long-term solutions.

What You Can Do

You don't need to know everything about SGMA, but staying informed and asking the right questions puts you in a better position. Here are some things you can do right now:

- **Log your pumping.** Whether or not you're required to meter yet, start keeping records. Familiarity with your own usage will make future compliance easier.
- **Know your allocation.** Draft allocation policies are moving forward. Ask questions now, before the rules are finalized, to understand how your pumping rights may change over the next fifteen years.
- **Pay attention to recharge opportunities.** Policies around credits are evolving. If you're doing on-farm recharge or are interested in it, now's the time to speak up and learn where your GSA stands.
- **Talk to your neighbors.** Shared understanding builds local resilience. If you've figured something out, help someone else. If you're confused, ask.
- **Stay involved.** Whether it's First Fridays, stakeholder meetings, or conversations with GSA reps, stay in the loop. Local engagement is how we shape the future, not just react to it.

The Path Ahead

Each month introduces new actions and responsibilities. In the Tulare Lake Subbasin, agencies are transitioning from planning to implementation. The policies being developed now will shape how groundwater is managed in the future. That's why your voice, your choices, and your participation matter more than ever.

Julie Martella is an independent consultant specializing in SGMA implementation, narrative strategy, and community trust building. She tracks groundwater policy across the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

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